

YOUR WEEKLY DECISION • BEFORE YOU STEP AWAY

You Prepared the Business. Did You Prepare Yourself?

BY RJ FINLEY

Sometimes the most important part of selling your business isn't the terms of the deal. It's what happens the Monday after.

I sat down with a woman a couple years back, I'll call her Lisa, to finalize the transition plan on her company. Sixty-one years old, three decades building a manufacturing business from nothing. She'd done everything right. The right buyer, a strong valuation, a team that was ready. Everything was in place.

And right as we're about to walk through the plan, she stops. Just goes quiet for a second. Then she says, "I've spent years getting the business ready for this moment. But I'm not sure I ever got myself ready."

I've heard some version of that more times than I can count. Founders pour everything into the financial and operational side of a sale, the stuff with deadlines and dollar signs, and somehow the person in the middle of it all gets left out of the planning entirely.

So here's what I walk through with everyone before they step away. Three things, and only one of them is about the business.

First, can the business actually run without you? This is the one founders usually have handled, or think they do. Buyers want to know the company doesn't live or die on your daily involvement. That means your key processes are written down instead of living in your head, your leadership team can actually make decisions without calling you, and your books are clean enough to survive due diligence without a story attached to every line. Lisa already had a strong team. But she went further and spent months mentoring her COO to take over the relationships and the big calls. That move did

two things. It reassured the buyer, and it gave Lisa the quiet confidence that she wasn't leaving a mess behind.

Second, and this is the one nobody preps for, what are you actually going to do next? Selling a business isn't just a transaction. It's a life event. For thirty years you knew exactly who you were the moment your feet hit the floor. Then one day that's just gone. So before you sell, sit with the real questions. What do my days actually look like when I step away? Where do I get challenged and useful now? Do I even want to be fully out, or do I want a foot still in the door? Lisa decided to stay on as a board advisor for eighteen months. It gave her a bridge instead of a cliff, and it gave the new leadership room to find their footing.

Third, what is all of this going to mean? A sale is a legacy moment whether you treat it like one or not. It's your one clean chance to decide what the whole thing was for, for your family, your employees, the community that showed up for you along the way. So have the real conversations with your family before the deal, not after. Get honest about what you actually want your money to do. Structure the sale so it feeds your long-term plan instead of just landing a number in an account. Lisa took part of her proceeds and started a foundation focused on workforce development in her industry. She took what she'd built and pointed it back at the people who helped her build it.

Here's what I've come to believe after enough of these. A good transition isn't measured by how much you squeezed out of the company. It's measured by how little you regret a year later. It's about leaving on your own terms, with clarity instead of whiplash, and an actual plan for what's next.

Lisa didn't just sell her company. She handed off something she loved with a steady hand, and she walked into the next chapter with peace instead of a pit in her stomach.

Client name is fictitious for confidentiality.

THIS WEEK'S DECISION

This week, decide: you've spent years getting the business ready to hand off. Have you spent even one afternoon getting yourself ready?

If any of this hit close to home, let's talk it through. No pitch, just a real conversation about what's next.

Know a founder who's closer to selling than they let on? Forward this to them. The best transitions start years before the deal does.

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